Social media can be instrumental in helping young people stay connected, as is evident in the quote from the student in Sialkot; awareness of politics or current affairs, to the extent that this information translates into a political conscience that would result in political action, often varies across individuals, as evident in the student quotes. However, the response of Pakistan's security state, its need to control social media and online platforms, which are perceived to be spaces that can promote anti-state and terrorist propaganda, implies that the space has the potential to disrupt the 'national narrative'; therefore these platforms are considered dangerous by the security state.

There have been cases such as Noreen Leghari's in which young people have been radicalized online through social media. Leghari, a nineteen-year-old student who left home, married a militant and joined Daesh; she blamed social media for her radicalization, in particular Facebook and Instagram through which she was recruited, and exposed to militant and extremist content (Daily Times 2017; Dawn 2017a). In order to prevent such online spaces, the Prevention of Electronic Crimes Act (PECA) introduced in 2016 increased control and surveillance of the internet. However, given the discussion in Chapter 4, the nature of this terrorist or anti-state threat is determined more by strategic interests, where certain extremist groups are allowed to flourish, while civil society and human rights groups are considered anti-state. The surveillance further targets content that is deemed blasphemous by the authorities. In June 2017, Taimoor Raza became the first Pakistani to be sentenced to death by an anti-terrorism court for 'allegedly committing blasphemy on Facebook' (Rasmussen and Gillani 2017). Belonging to the minority Shia community, Raza was involved in 'a debate about Islam on Facebook' with a man who turned out to be an employee of the Counterterrorism Department (CTD). Raza's arrest was part of a wider crackdown on social media activism by the Ministry of Interior. In March 2017 the interior ministry asked the social media site Facebook 'to help investigate "blasphemous content" posted on the social network by Pakistanis' (BBC News 2017a). The Ministry has further moved to criminalize any activity on social media that is critical of the Pakistani army (Dawn 2017b).

This chapter examines the presence and policing of social media in Pakistan. It highlights how state policy towards preserving a 'national narrative' about the country that glorifies the army, criminalizes dissent and promotes an exclusive religious identity, is also reinforced on social media. Such criminalization of activity online is also problematic in a context where law enforcement authorities are ill-equipped and lack training in dealing with 'online' crimes committed by individuals. It further leads to a securitization of online spaces, evident in cases